

Google & Microsoft Ads Attribution — Full Specification v2

Digistore24 × Hyder Media · 2026-09-02 · supersedes spec of 2026-07-23

Goal: complete, durable attribution from paid click !' vendor signup !' activation !' revenue, sufficient to measure channel ROAS on the agreed 1-year CLTV basis. Prepared for the Digistore24 engineering and data teams.

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1 · Current state (measured, as of 2026-09-02)

The August 21 fix works and is verified — this section is what your change achieved and where the ceiling is.

- **DONE** — gclid capture is LIVE for US/BR traffic since 2026-08-21 via the event-property path on signup events. US capture reached ~27% of signups — statistical parity with your own DACH campaigns (~28%). Brazil trails at 4–8%.
- **DONE** — The full funnel is joinable in PostHog: signup (gclid) !' Product Creation Started !' First Sale (userId) !' Purchase Completed (vendor_id). Hyder Media syncs cohorts daily to the client dashboard automatically.
- **DONE** — Early cohort signal: 19% of attributed US signups begin product creation; first sales appear at a median ~8 days (DACH benchmark: 2.7% of signups reach first sale by week 10).
- **GAP** — The capture mechanism reads the gclid from the page URL. Any visitor who navigates between pages before signup loses the parameter — which is why capture plateaus near 27% for every geo. Roughly 3 of 4 paid signups remain unattributed. Rates measured on the captured sample are trustworthy; absolute attributed counts and revenue are ~4× understated.
- **GAP** — ~97% of stored gclid values account-wide are the literal string "None" (empty values serialized). Analytically survivable, but it pollutes person properties and inflates naive queries.
- **GAP** — Purchase-record coverage is unconfirmed: only 20 of 93 activated vendors join to purchase events, matches are EUR-only. Revenue per vendor is currently a floor, not a measurement.

2 · Requirements to reach full attribution

R1 — Cookie-based click-ID capture (replaces URL-parameter dependence) [dev · ~1 day]

At signup (and ideally on \$identify), read the click ID from the first-party cookies Google and Microsoft already maintain on .digistore24.com, with the URL parameter as first preference:

```
gclid = url.gclid || cookie("_gcl_aw").split(".")[2] // Google
msclkid = url.msclkid || cookie("_uetmsclkid")?.replace(/^_uet/, "") // Microsoft
```

- The _gcl_aw cookie is set by the Google tag on every ad click and survives multi-page journeys and the funnel handoff — it is how your own Google Ads conversion tracking already works. Expected capture: 80–90%+ (also lifts your DACH campaigns above today's ~28%).
- Microsoft Ads launched for this account on 2026-08-25 (account G1456B2Z) with UET installed — capture msclkid with the same pattern so Bing attribution exists from month one. Store as a separate property (msclkid), never mixed with gclid.
- Send null / omit the property when absent — never the string "None". If feasible, backfill-clean existing "None" values or simply leave them; our queries exclude them.

R2 — Cover every funnel domain [dev · hours]

- The Aug 21 fix covers the experience.digistore24.com funnel. New landing pages now run on pages.digistore24.com (first campaign traffic started 2026-08-31) — the same capture (or the R1 cookie-read, which makes this moot) must apply to signups originating there.

- Rule going forward: any new funnel subdomain inherits click-ID capture by default. The cookie approach satisfies this automatically because the cookie lives at the root domain.

R3 — Persist attribution on the vendor record (write-once) [dev · ~1 day, from v1 spec]

Unchanged from the July 23 spec — first-touch, write-once fields on the vendor/user record at account creation:

acq_gclid · acq_msclkid · acq_source · acq_medium · acq_campaign · acq_content
acq_landing_page · acq_first_seen_at · acq_signup_at

- PostHog person properties are useful but mutable and tool-scoped; the vendor record is the durable system of record that survives analytics migrations and powers finance-grade reporting.
- Aggregate-only exports keep this outside personal-data scope per the DPA (suppress rows < 5 vendors if preferred).

R4 — Confirm the revenue join [data team · one answer, no code]

- Question, verbatim: is First Sale.userId the same identifier space as Purchase Completed.vendor_id, and does the Purchase Completed event cover ALL order forms and currencies?
- Observed: only 20/93 activated vendors match purchases, EUR-only, while platform-wide purchase events do include USD (\$1.05M/30d) — so this looks like an ID-space or event-coverage gap, not currency instrumentation.
- Until confirmed, vendor GMV (and therefore DS24 margin per acquired vendor) is a floor. This single answer converts the 1-year ROAS estimate from a 1.0×–1.7× band into a number.

R5 — Close the loop: offline conversion feeds [dev · 2–3 days · highest ROI after R1]

- Nightly job: for vendors whose acq_gclid is set and who reached activation (First Sale) since the last run, upload an offline conversion "Vendor Activation" (with revenue value once R4 lands) via the Google Ads API; mirror with msclkid ! Microsoft Ads offline conversions.
- Effect: both ad platforms' bidding optimizes toward vendors who activate and sell, rather than raw signups. In funnels of this shape this is typically worth 20–40% acquisition efficiency — it is where attribution stops being reporting and starts making money.
- Hyder Media can own the ad-platform side (conversion actions, upload mapping) — Digistore24 only exposes a (click_id, activated_at, value) feed.

3 · Acceptance tests

- T1: Test click with gclid !' browse 2+ pages !' signup !' PostHog signup event AND vendor record carry the gclid (proves cookie path).
- T2: Same flow from a pages.digistore24.com landing page.
- T3: Same flow from a Microsoft ad (msclkid).
- T4: US capture rate in the daily monitor (already live, Hyder-side) rises from ~27% toward 80%+ within a week of R1 deploy — we watch this automatically and will confirm.
- T5: R4 answered !' activated-vendor purchase-match rate reported; target > 90% of activated vendors joinable to purchase records.
- T6: Offline conversions visible in Google Ads (conversion action "Vendor Activation") within 48h of an activation.

4 · Context: how we got here

- Jul 23 — v1 spec delivered: gclid dropped at experience-funnel !' signup bare-URL handoff; cookie-read recommended.
- Aug 11–13 — PostHog analysis: funnel fully instrumented; "None" pollution identified; DACH benchmark cohort measured (2.7% activation @ 10 wks, ~8-day time-to-first-sale, whale-driven GMV). US/BR capture confirmed ~0%.

- Aug 21 — Digistore24 ships URL-parameter capture fix. US capture rises 0% !' 27% (verified by daily monitor).
- Aug 25 — Microsoft Ads launches (G1456B2Z); UET tag live; msclkid capture not yet implemented (R1).
- Aug 31 — New landing-page domain pages.digistore24.com enters rotation (R2).

Requirements R1 + R4 are the two smallest items and unlock the most: R1 quadruples attributed volume, R4 turns revenue floors into measurements. Both are prerequisites for the 1-year CLTV ROAS measurement Digistore24 requested. — Hyder Media